Day 1 - Choosing Your Agritourism Niche.

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The Agritourism Trend

Agritourism revenue more than tripled between 2002 and 2017, according to data from the Census of Agriculture. Adjusted for inflation, agritourism revenue grew from $704 million in 2012 to almost $950 million in 2017. More than 28,000 farms across the country now embrace agritourism, resulting in nearly a billion dollars in direct sales from people visiting those farms start implementing them right away.

Who is this course for?

This is a 5-day course is for people who own a farm, ranch, vineyard, or other property and want to learn ways to generate more income. This course is for farmers, ranchers, and property owners who are already doing agritourism but want to grow more income from it. It can also be very beneficial for farmers, ranchers, and property owners who are just getting started on their agritourism journey.

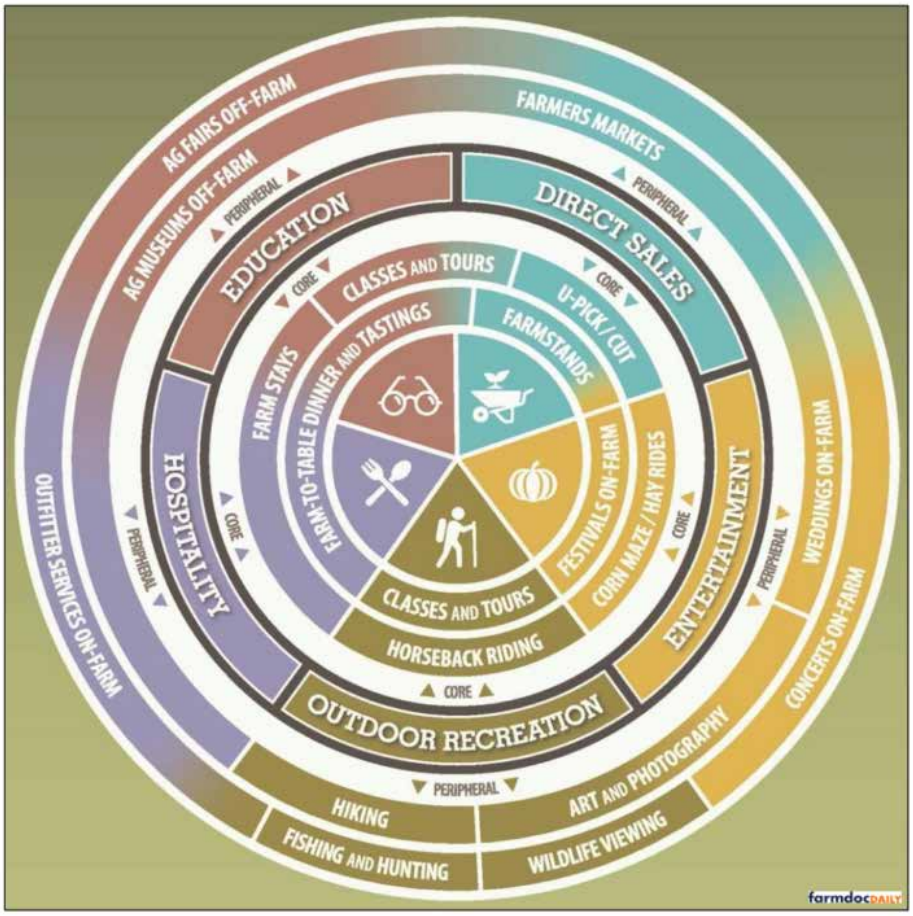
Every day, for the next 4 days, we're going to teach you about ways that you can grow the revenue of your agritourism business.

What is agritourism?

Agritourism is the combination of agriculture and tourism. Agritourism can include...

- **Education**, such as school tours, garden and nursery tours, winery tours, historical agricultural exhibits, and hops and micro-brewery tours;
- **Outdoor recreation**, such as river activities, mountain biking, horseback riding, wildlife viewing and photography, fee fishing and hunting, wagon and sleigh rides, cross-country skiing, game preserves, and clay bird shooting;
- **Entertainment,** such as concerts and special events, culinary experiences, festivals, fairs, interaction with farm animals, and weddings;
- **Direct sales,** such as on-farm sales, farm stands, agriculture-related crafts and gifts, u-pick operations, u-cut tree farms, wineries, breweries, cideries, distilleries, and cut flowers;
- **Accommodations,** such as bred-and-breakfast inns, farms and ranch vacations, yurts, sheep wagons, guest ranches; and
- Dining on a farm.

(Source: farmdoccast)



Why Agritourism?

Here are some of the common reasons farms are turning to agritourism...
They want to make more money from their farms.
They want recurring and diversified revenue streams.
They want a competitive advantage.
They need to combat higher costs and inflation.
They want to generate more consistent income during the year.
They want to keep farmland in their family.
Help urbanites connect with nature.
They want to share their love of farming with others.

Examples of Agritourism

Here's some examples of places around the US where they have found what makes them unique and how they share it with their guests.

Liberty Hill Farm - Rochester, Vermont[1]

"This family-run dairy farm has welcomed tourists since 1984. Adults and kids of all ages can take part in an array of activities, from milking cows and bottle-feeding calves to fly-fishing and hiking. Of course, you'll need energy for all that. Luckily, a stay at Liberty Hill Farm includes lodging and meals. Days begin with a hearty breakfast and end with a home-cooked dinner."

Willow-Witt Ranch -Ashland, Oregon[1]

"Seeking an off-the-grid escape? Consider Willow-Witt Ranch in southern Oregon. Guided by a commitment to environmental conservation and sustainable agriculture, this 445-acre property beckons visitors to discover the bounty of nature. There are some 200 plant varieties on the grounds, plus tons of animals. Whether you prefer gathering eggs, feeding pigs or sowing seeds, you'll find plenty of Arcadian pursuits to fill your time."

Blackberry Farm - Walland, Tennessee[1]

"Situated on 4,200 pristine acres in the foothills of the Great Smoky Mountains, Blackberry Farm is a gastronomic destination, where traditional aggie practices still thrive. Guests are encouraged to participate in foraging excursions, gardening seminars, tasting tours and cooking classes at the acclaimed restaurant. Of course, epicurean delights aren't the only draw. Horseback riding and archery are also popular."

Hidden Villa - Los Altos Hills, California[1]

"When you think of Silicon Valley you probably don't envision the countryside, but maybe you should. Forget high-speed internet and social media — Hidden Villa (a nonprofit educational organization) is a tech-free zone, where roosters replace alarm clocks and the gentle babbling of Adobe Creek lulls you to sleep at night. In addition to farm stays, the 1,651-acre land trust hosts after-school programs and summer camps."

Monteillet Fromagerie - Dayton, Washington[1]

"Monteillet Fromagerie is the first artisanal cheese farmstead in the Walla Walla Valley — although it feels more like France than Washington. Run by Pierre-Louis and Joan Monteillet, the riverfront retreat is a glorious getaway. Rent the gite (French for "holiday home") and spend a few days soaking in the rustic charm, mingling with animals and mastering the art of hand-ladled chevre."

Inn at Valley Farms - Walpole, New Hampshire[1]

"Agrarian enthusiasts flock to the Inn at Valley Farms, part of a multigenerational countryside estate in the fertile Monadnock Region of New Hampshire. Rooms are cozy and comfortable. Free weekly movie nights in the barn enhance the experience. Before you depart, stock up on grass-fed beef, local maple syrup and homemade jams as well as pasture-raised chickens, turkeys, pork and eggs at the farm store."

Taos Goji - El Prado, New Mexico[1]

"Nestled in San Cristobal, Taos Goji is an organic farm that offers WWOOFers (those are World Wide Opportunities on Organic Farms volunteers) and foodies alike a chance to stay on a homestead dating back to the 1880s. Historic cabins are fitted with functional kitchens, bathrooms, wood-fire stoves and eco-friendly linens. Also up for grabs? Real-life lessons in harvesting, adobe brick building, caring for livestock and beekeeping."

Mountain Goat Lodge - Salida, Colorado[1]

"Mountain Goat Lodge is a bucolic farm and B&B in the high desert of Colorado. Visitors get to interact with dairy goats and even bottle-feed kids (depending on the season). More than just cute pets, these critters provide milk for in-house cheese-making. Burgeoning shepherds can take classes on breeding, raising, herding and husbandry."

1-https://www.usatoday.com/story/travel/destinations/2018/06/15/agritourism-8-farm-and-food-experiences-usa/702848002/

Agritourism Ideas

Here's a list of some agritourism ideas to help you brainstorm. See what ideas spark interest and would add value to your business. Many of these ideas would be low-cost to start. Pick your favorites and make a plan to start implementing them right away.

Animal Kennel
Apple Butter Making
Archery
Arts/Crafts Demonstrations
Astronomy Observations
Banquet Facilities
Barn Dances
Bee Bearding
Bird Watching
Bonfire
Cabin Rentals
Camping
Canoeing
Catering Services
Cattle Roping/Branding
Cave Tours
Children's Camps
Christmas Trees
Chuck Wagon Dinners
Cider Mill Demonstrations
Classes/Clinics/Demonstrations
Cooking Demonstrations
Corn Cannon
Corn Mazes
Corporate Retreats
Crop Art
Custom Slaughter (Domestic And Wild)
Dairy Shares
Demonstrations
Dude Ranches
Educational Tours
Excursions
Farm Schools
Farm Theme Playground
Farm Tours
Farm/Ranch Vacations
Farmers Markets
Fishing
Floral Arrangements
Fly Fishing/Tying Clinics
Food Festivals
Food Stands
Game Preserving
Garden Tours
Goat Walks
Guided Hunting
Guiding And Outfitting
Habitat Improvement Projects
Harvest
Haunted Houses
Haunted Woods
Hay Bale Maze (All Kinds Of Mazes)
Hay Rides
Haying Or Other Harvesting Experiences
Herb Harvesting
Herb Walks
Hiking
Historical Museums/Displays
Horse Boarding
Horse Instruction
Horseback Riding
Horseshoeing
Host Local Festivals/Holidays
Hunting Dog Training/Competitions
Hunting
Laser Tag
Lecture/Seminar/Classes
Living History Events
Miniature Golf
Mushroom Harvesting
Nature Photography
Off-Road Motorcycling
ATV
Mountain Biking
On-Farm Retailing
Organic Food Production
Outdoor Concerts/Plays
Outdoor Games
Pack Trips
Paintball
Petting Farm
Photography/Painting Lessons
Picnic Sites
Picnics
Pizza Farms
Pony Rides
Processing Demonstrations
Pumpkin Carving
Ranch Skills
Refreshment Sales
Rentals (Boats, Canoes, Floral Plants, Fishing Rods, Etc)
Roadside Markets
Rock Climbing/Rappelling
Rock Collecting
Rodeo
School Tours
Self-Guided Tours
Sheep Shearing Demonstrations
Skating
Sledding
Sleigh Rides
Swimming
Tubing/Rafting
U-Pick
Wagon Trains
Water Slides
Weddings
Wilderness Experiences
Wildlife Observation
Wool Processing
Working Farm Stays
Workshops (Wreaths, Gardening)

What is Your Differentiator?

Here are some questions to help you find your differentiator... what makes you unique in your area as an agritourism business? _____

What makes my property amazing or different? _____

Do I have water access? _____

Do I grow a crop that can be picked easily by others (think strawberries, apples, etc)? _____

Can I preserve (can, freeze dry, etc.) what I grow? _____

Do I have a view that makes others stop and stare? _____

What activities can my visitors do on or near my property? _____

Do I have any buildings or land that has historical value? _____

What things am I already tried doing to increase revenue on my property? _____

What worked well? And what did not work well? _____

Do I like interacting with other people or does it drain me? _____

Do I have special equipment other opportunities that guests would want to engage with, such as snowmobiles, horses, etc.? _____

Do I have skills or resources that guests would like to learn about or would appreciate? _____

Today's Action

Your action item for today is to pick one or more ways you could generate additional agritourism income from your property.

Start by making a list of the top elements that differentiate your property. Then, prioritize those differentiators. Brainstorm ways you can monetize that differentiator.

For example, do you have a fire pit? Consider selling a picnic basket with all the things your guests need for smores. Or, does your property border a river? Maybe you could rent fly fishing gear and fly fishing lessons. If you grow strawberries, maybe you offer fresh, homemade strawberry waffles for breakfast and a jar of homemade strawberry jam with a loaf of homemade bread and peanut butter for lunch.

Once you have made your prioritized list, please search Google for other agritourism businesses around the country providing similar services and research what they are doing, to help give you ideas. You may even want to reach out to those agritourism businesses, explain to them what you are considering, and get their feedback.

We also recommend you look at other agritourism businesses in your area, understand what they are doing, and be sure you're selecting agritourism services that differentiate you and give you a competitive advantage.

Once you have selected one or more new agritourism services you want to add, make a plan of when and how you are going to implement it. You may want to test the new service on a small scale and see how your customers respond before you put a lot of time and money into it. You may want to test several new services and figure out which one gets the best response.

Tomorrow: Day 2

Tomorrow's lesson will teach how we can leverage our community to grow our agritourism business.

This course is brought to you by CurbNTurf, a service kind of like AirBNB, but we connect agritourism businesses and other property owners with RVers who need a place to stay while they're traveling. CurbNTurf can help bring more customers to your agritourism business, plus help you generate new income streams as the RVers pay to stay on your property. To learn more about listing your property for free on CurbNTurf, please visit: https://www.curbnturf.com/host. Or you can call us at (800) 877-5005 with an questions. We can also help you get the CurbNTurf listing for your property set up.

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